INTRODUCTION

A ‘Jai Sri Ram’ Sticker and a Family Argument: The BJP and a Personal Retracing

My family’s first domestic political fight, as far as I can remember, was over the Ram Temple. My grandfather brought a ‘Jai Sri Ram’ (Victory to Lord Ram) sticker from somewhere and pasted it on the front of my father’s Bajaj 150 scooter. Dad blew his top.

My grandfather could not understand this reaction. ‘Ram is our God. We worship him every day in this house. What’s your problem with a sticker that has his name?’ he asked with furious indignation.

‘Yes, but this is now a political slogan. I am in the Army,’ responded my father. ‘It would be treason to sport a political sticker and drive this scooter while wearing my uniform,’ I remember him saying.

It was September 1990. L.K. Advani, then president of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), had just started his 10,000-km Rath Yatra (literally, ‘chariot journey’), from the ancient reconstructed temple of Somnath on the western Gujarat coast to the disputed Babri Masjid site in Ayodhya in the heart of Uttar Pradesh (UP).

India’s current prime minister, Narendra Modi, had just started making his name in Gujarat as a local BJP apparatchik. His name first appeared as a politician in the pages of *The Times of India* in 1988, as the organiser of an anti-Congress rasta-roko agitation on farmer demands in Gujarat,[1] but not many outside the state had heard of him. That wider recognition would not come until he became a key organiser of the Yatra’s Gujarat leg in 1990.[2] The first